

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

20–25 min · Week 24 · Permanent Post

OBJECTIVE	Students learn the four-step Pause Practice for charitable interpretation, and articulate that we usually give the benefit of the doubt to people we like — the practice begins where the kind story runs out.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness · charitable interpretation; Self-Management: pausing reactivity
VOCABULARY	benefit of the doubt · pause · charitable · kind story · first thought · choose
MATERIALS	Sammy puppet · The Pause Practice anchor chart · scenario cards (Unit 4 Lesson 3 cards)

OPENING REVIEW · 1–2 MIN

Show the Mercy chart. "Last lesson: mercy is a choice. Today: a tool we use BEFORE we even know if mercy is needed. We use it when something happens and we don't know WHY.**"

SAMMY · KIND COACH VOICE

"Someone bumped into me in the hall. I didn't know if they did it on purpose. My brain said 'mean!' But — wait — there is another way to see this."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 5

1

Step 1 · Something Happens

3 MIN

Begin: "Something ambiguous happens. You do not know WHY someone did what they did. Did they mean to? Did they not see? Were they having a hard day? You do not know. Yet.**"

2

Step 2 · Notice Your First Thought

4 MIN

Continue: "Your brain has a FIRST thought. 'They did it on purpose!' 'They are mean!' NOTICE the thought. Do NOT act on it yet. Just notice.**"

3

Step 3 · Pause

4 MIN

The crucial step: "PAUSE. Ask: 'What is another way to see this — a kind one?' Maybe they did not see you. Maybe they were rushing to help someone. Maybe they were having a hard day. A KIND story might be true.**"

4

Step 4 · Act on the Kind Story

5 MIN

The action: "Unless you KNOW for sure — act on the KIND story. 'They probably did not see me.' 'They are probably having a hard day.' You can be wrong about this. You usually won't be.**"